

Cover story

Kalahandi Revisited

It was a symbol of India's rural darkness: Orissa's Kalahandi, where the sale of a baby for Rs 40 shocked the world in 1985. Phanas Punji of Amla-palli village had sold her two-year-old sister-in-law Banita to save her own two children from dying of starvation. Her tale of misery was so shocking that it led to a series of schemes by the Centre and the state government. For the past eight years, Kalahandi has been getting Rs 30 crore as development funds. Today, Banita wears a decent sari, gold nose rings and earrings. She works at the local Anganwadi centre and earns Rs 500 a month. Besides, she like others in dire straits, were given Rs 9,000 for constructing a dwelling and Rs 13,000 to construct a well under the Jivandhara scheme. As many as 20 houses in the area have got electricity connections, 15 have tv sets. There is a solar power tower. Over 40 per cent of the land has been brought under assured irrigation and helped change the crop pattern from mono crop to multi-crop. Kalahandi was India's darkest stain, it now reflects its brightest hope.

by Farzand Ahmed

RURAL INDIA



SHRIYA PATIL, SHINDE/www.indiatodayimages.com

on tv. They now need generators to run the gadgets they own. Malls and multiplexes have sprouted in recent years, catering mostly to rural youth. Not all is good news. Sociologists believe rural youth are getting self-indulgent and squandering the money their parents made by land sales. "This is leading to sociological pressures as rural people ape urban lifestyles," says Manmohan Singh Gill, a sociology professor,

Access to Finance Meet the Spice Girls, who can be found at the vegetable market in Santhivila, a village on the outskirts of Thiruvananthapuram. They are a group of 16 young women who have changed the local economy. They are members of Karunya, a women's self-help group registered with Kudumbasree, the state Government's Poverty Eradication Project. None of them had a job till they formed Karunya in 2007. The local gram panchayat gave the group Rs 1 lakh and space at the local vegetable market. With the seed money, they took a bank loan to start a unit making paper boards, cloth bags, office files, pens, pencils etc. The Kudumbasree Mission provided them technical training and today Karunya is one of the most popular brands in these products. Their environmentally safe paper files

PALLE GANGA REDDY
DIRECTOR, ANDHRA
PRADESH STATE
SEEDS CORPORATION

Seed companies in the Armoor block of the Nizamabad district encouraged farmers to produce red jowar in the 1980s and offered them a buy-back guarantee. Since then, the region produces nearly 70 per cent of the national requirement and the seeds are sold in the northern states. New farming techniques and technology have created large scale employment.

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